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MythBusting #2

“It’s Not Worth it to Pay For Cybersecurity”

“Since I haven’t been hacked yet, why spend money on cybersecurity? It just seems like a waste of money.” This myth shows up everywhere. In startups looking to quickly rollout products, in small businesses counting pennies every month, or even on large organizations trying to meet annual targets. As Bruce Schneier argues in “Secrets and Lies,” people and organizations value privacy and security right up until it becomes inconvenient or costly, then it is the first thing sacrificed. This myth comes from chapter 5 of Schneier’s “Secrets and Lies,” where he states: “People have a complicated relationship with privacy. When asked to pay for it, they often don’t want to.” He goes on to explain how businesses invest in locks, cameras, alarms, and firewall, yet they cut corners when it comes to cybersecurity.

Imagine a restaurant owner who decides to not pay for food safety inspections because they have never had a food poisoning incident. The owner might see this as justifiable, until one outbreak sickens dozens of customers. Medical bills, lawsuits, and reputational damage will quickly add up and far exceed the cost of the cut food inspections. The absence of past disasters does not mean the absence of risk. This logic directly applies in cybersecurity, where many organizations operate for years without a visible breach and say that spending money on cybersecurity is unnecessary. This is exactly the attitude attackers look for in potential victims, as attacks are not random but opportunistic.

Belief in this myth can create serious harm. It can optimize short term profits, but it severely increases long term risks of catastrophic loss. Belief can lead to skipping the creation of backups and strong authentication, which increases the likelihood of severe breaches. It also seriously reduces trust in customers, patients, clients, or citizens as they expect their data to be protected. A breach can damage credibility and can permanently reduce user confidence. Many organizations are part of a larger system, so vulnerabilities in one company can become an entry point into supply chains or infrastructure.

Cybersecurity should not be evaluated as part of a company’s profit management, but their risk management. A more accurate belief in contrast to this myth would be “Cybersecurity is an investment in reducing the likelihood and impact of costly failure.” No organization can eliminate all risk, the goal is to reduce risk to an acceptable level and cost. Foundational controls, security-focused systems, and acceptance of security costs are a necessity. We pay for insurance, fire alarms, and inspections to manage risk, which cybersecurity does in spades.